

thrashed them through some of the most taxing applications around just for fun; and to aid you in choosing one.

For the benchmark gurus:
PC Mark 05 And 3D Mark 06

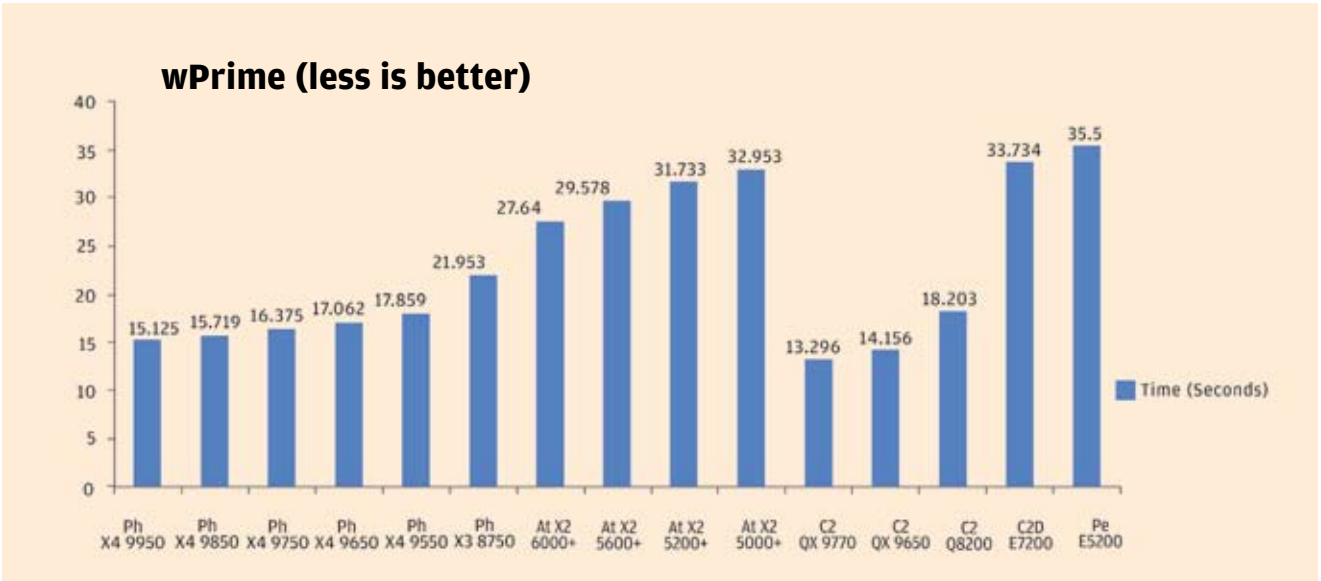
The answers are in the stars, as it's said. Intel's QX9770 and QX9650 CPUs reach for the stars with some superb scores; the QX9770 being the only processor to actually cross a CPU score of 10,000 in PC Mark 05. A mini battle takes place between the two similarly positioned quad cores; AMD's Phenom X4 9950 and Intel's Q8200 which are very close to other with a small advantage going to AMD. The Phenom

X4 9850 is very close to the Q8200 as well, but is a little slower. Interestingly the Phenom X4 9950 is cheaper than the Q8200 by Rs 985. What's interesting to note is the way these scores scale with the number of cores; very much like a stepladder. CPUs having an identical number of processing cores will perform similarly, the next factor affecting them being core speeds. As we move up from two to three cores, there is a larger hike in performance as seen in case of the Athlon 6000+ and the Phenom X3 8750 in 3D Mark 06. A much higher clock speed advantage for the 6000+ (3.1 GHz VS 2.4 GHz for the X3 8750) isn't enough to push it past its sibling. Intel's slowest offering

the Pentium E5200 is faster than both of AMDs slowest offerings but is also costlier.

Number crunching:
wPrime 1.55

We were very interested to check these scores as this benchmark scales very well with multi core CPUs while being ultra sensitive to clock speed changes. It's a superb test for the math computational grunt of your CPU. Intel's QX 9770 and QX9650 are unstoppable in this test and both crack the sub-15 second barrier. But these CPUs cost more than four times the amount you pay for AMDs costliest CPU, which is not acceptable under any conditions.



Intel's Q8200 which is slightly costlier than AMDs X4 9950 is demolished by that worthy, in fact all the AMD X4 Phenom's outperform it. AMD is faster than Intel in general throughout this benchmark and even the cheaper Athlon X2 CPUs have fun dancing circles around the E5200 and E7200 CPUs from Intel.

For the scientist:
ScienceMark 2.0

Sadly ScienceMark 2.0 doesn't seem to scale with the number of cores. This benchmark favours higher clock speeds more as a cheap high-clocked dual-core pro-

cessor (AMDs 6000+) steals the thunder from the likes of the QX9770 which is ten times costlier. Shockingly the fastest Intel CPUs are clocked at nearly the same clock speeds as the 6000+ which runs at 3.1 GHz; this means AMDs architecture is much better at dealing with ScienceMark's computations. We shudder to think what would happen to Intel in this benchmark if a Phenom X4 were to be clocked at around 3.2 GHz. The QX9770 and QX9650 are the second and third fastest CPUs in this test, after which its time for the 5600+ to strut it's stuff; this CPU creams the Q8200 which costs more than twice

of the 5600+'s meagre price of Rs 4,600. In terms of encryption Intel's lower CPUs do not scale at all, their Core 2 Quad 8200 is identical to the Pentium E5200. The Q8200 itself is faster than the mighty QX9650 in terms of memory bandwidth.

The rendering standard:
CineBench R10

CineBench R10 is designed ground-up for multi core CPUs. Because of the nature of this benchmark we naturally assume all those interested in any sort of image editing or 3D rendering works would closely look at

